

Team-Led Pilot to Reduce Performance Pressure and Keep Best Workers

- Associates face rigid, algorithm-driven rate enforcement with little human judgment or flexibility built in
- This drives unfairness perceptions, erodes trust in leadership, and accelerates attrition
- What can a site team actually do about this, without waiting for corporate policy change?
- 12-week pilot targeting the managerial layer can surface and reduce pressure without new systems or headcount
- **5** - friction flows identified across two employee segments
- **3** - root causes sustaining the pressure system
- **12** - weeks: pilot duration to first measurable finding

Rigid Rate Enforcement Makes Workers Feel Trapped

System Cause	Human Effect	Business Risk
● Algorithm sets rate targets with no human override ● Write-up system triggers automatically near threshold ● High management turnover → rule enforcement, not judgment	● Workers hit targets under task-mix and resourcing conditions they can't control ● Associates fear speaking up, absorbing pressure silently ● No human buffer between the algorithm and the worker	● Perceived unfairness → disengagement and quiet attrition ● Safety compromised when productivity is prioritised over wellbeing ● Problem self-conceals: high turnover refreshes the workforce before signals reach leadership

“Keeping your job depends on your rate — your rate can depend on your waterspider who may not care that you do not have enough work to make rate and stay out of the bottom 5%.” – Warehouse Associate, Glassdoor

Warehouse Associates Carry the Highest Friction Load

- Who: Warehouse associates, picking and stowing roles
- Where: High-volume shifts, single picking departments
- Size: 30–50 associates per pilot team
- Why them: Richest friction signal in data - rate scrutiny, waterspider dependency, write-up pressure all concentrate here. Only segment with negative sentiment in the dataset.
- Picker/Stower → High rate expectations cause constant monitoring and micromanagement → Worker feels uncared for and disrespected → Disengagement and turnover
- Picker/Stower → Consequences for missing rate are inflexible (write-ups even when close to target) → Worker feels undervalued for effort put in → Loyalty and motivation erode

Coaching Manager Level: High Leverage, Low Cost, Team Level

How might we reduce rigid, compliance-first management enforcement for warehouse associates, so they no longer experience rate pressure as arbitrary or inescapable, and the business avoids the attrition and safety risk that follows?

Manager Coaching

- Equip Area Managers with tools to exercise judgment on rate expectations
- Focus: task-mix variability, waterspider coverage gaps
- Deliverable: structured coaching sessions + revised performance conversation guide
- Precedent: Costco - 85% internal promotion + supervisor training → ~7% turnover vs 60-70% industry norm

Worker Voice Channel

- Learning Ambassador collects a weekly 1-5 fairness score from 5-8 associates
- Protected channel: leadership commits no response triggers disciplinary review
- Deliverable: 10-week trend line of associate perception
- Precedent: Toyota NUMMI Andon cord - absenteeism fell from 20% to 2% when voice was made safe

Write-Up Calibration

- Review threshold and process for performance write-ups in high-variability conditions
- Goal: shift AM behaviour from documentation-as-default to judgment-first
- Deliverable: revised write-up guidance for pilot AM
- Precedent: Sam's Club - recalibrating performance system produced +16% productivity, -25% turnover

Twelve Weeks, One Team, Two Signals: Findings to Policy

Phase 1, Weeks 1-2: Baseline

- L.A. begins structured friction logging (no intervention yet)
- Establishes pre-intervention fairness score baseline
- HRBP pulls write-up rate baseline for pilot team

Phase 2, Weeks 3-8: Intervention

- AM coaching sessions begin
- Protected feedback channel opens
- Revised performance conversation guide in use
- Weekly fairness pulse collected by L.A.

Phase 3, Weeks 9-12: Measure

- Friction logging continues
- L.A. conducts close-out conversations with sample of associates
- HRBP compares write-up rate: pilot team vs site average
- Review meeting, at least one policy/process change considered

Who is Needed

- Learning Ambassador: signal collector + trusted conduit.
 - Needs: logging tool, protected channel, clear mandate
- Area Manager: human buffer + judgment lever.
 - Needs: coaching, revised guide, top cover from OM
- HR Business Partner: policy guardrail + data owner
 - Needs: pilot brief, monthly data review

Success Measures

- Measure 1: Weekly fairness pulse
 - Target: directional upward shift in average score over 8 active weeks
- Measure 2: Write-up rate
 - Target: reduction in pilot team vs site average and vs pre-pilot baseline